

MUSCA

THE FLY

A SMALL CONSTELLATION IMMEDIATELY TO THE SOUTH OF CRUX IN THE SOUTHERN SKY, MUSCA'S STARS ARE RELATIVELY BRIGHT BUT CAN GET LOST IN THE BACKGROUND OF THE MILKY WAY.

Musca is best located by first finding the brilliant stars of Crux. The fly is the sky's only insect. Its body is drawn around the constellation's brightest stars. First devised as Apis the bee by Dutch navigators Pieter Dirkszoon Keyser and Frederick de Houtman in the 1590s, it became a fly in the 1750s.



◁ NGC 5189

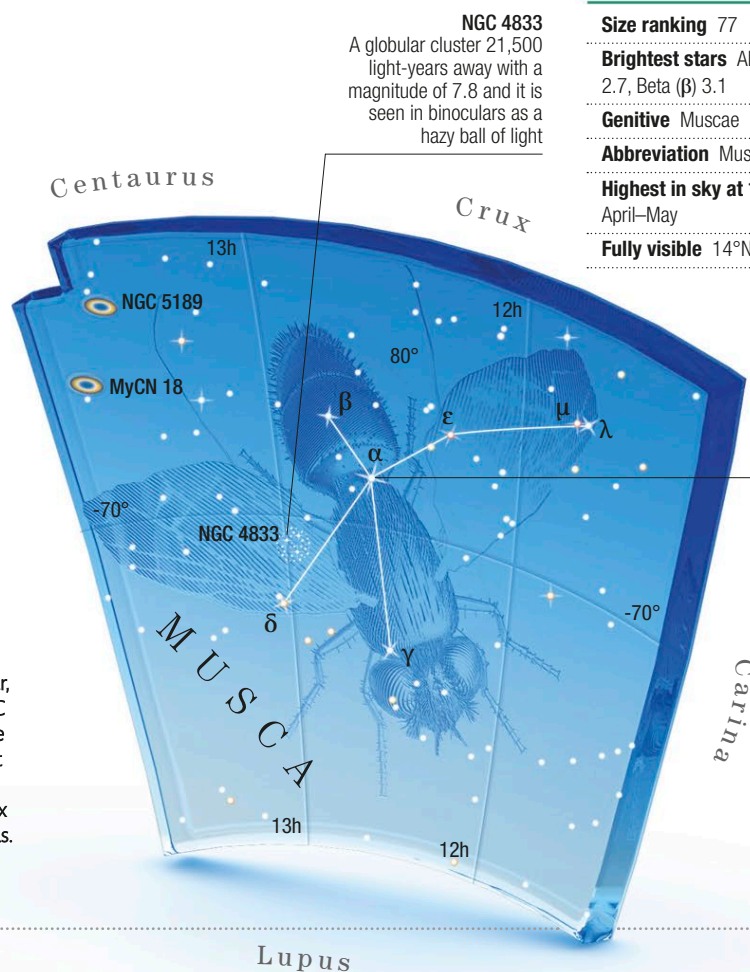
Also sometimes called the Spiral Planetary Nebula, NGC 5189 is a planetary nebula with expelled material rushing away from a dying star, a white dwarf. Unusually, NGC 5189 has two central stars; the white dwarf and a Wolf-Rayet type star. The presence of the two stars explains the complex structure of the surrounding gas.

KEY DATA

Size ranking 77
Brightest stars Alpha (α) 2.7, Beta (β) 3.1
Genitive Muscae
Abbreviation Mus
Highest in sky at 10pm April–May
Fully visible 14°N–90°S



CHART 2



Alpha (α) Muscae
 A blue-white subgiant evolving into a giant star, 315 light-years away. It is a Cepheid variable pulsating every 2.2 hours.

CIRCINUS

THE COMPASSES

ONE OF THE SMALLEST CONSTELLATIONS, CIRCINUS IS SQUEEZED INTO A GAP BETWEEN CENTAURUS AND TRIANGULUM AUSTRALE. IT IS BEST FOUND BY LOCATING THE BRIGHT STAR ALPHA CENTAURI.

Circinus was introduced by Frenchman Nicolas Louis de Lacaille in the 1750s. Drawn around a faint triangle of stars, it represents the compasses used by draftsmen and navigators. It includes the Circinus Galaxy, which is one of the closest Seyfert galaxies to us. Also noteworthy is RCW 86, the remnant from a supernova explosion witnessed by Chinese astronomers in 185 CE.



◁ RCW 86

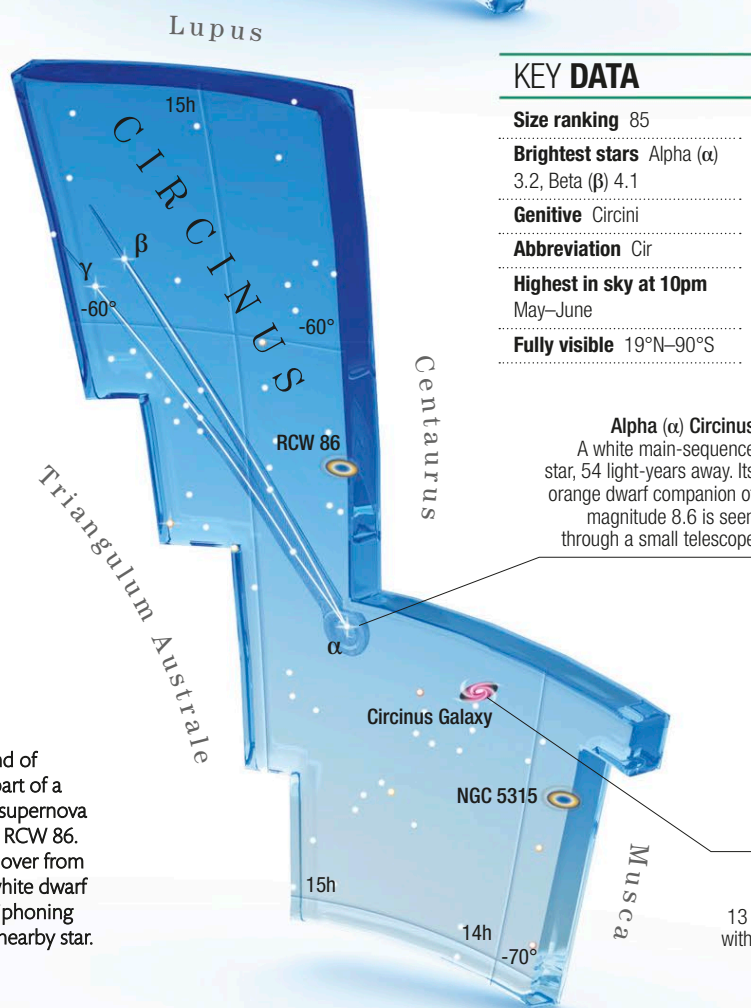
This colorful band of gas and dust is part of a roughly circular supernova remnant named RCW 86. It is material left over from a time when a white dwarf exploded after siphoning material from a nearby star.

KEY DATA

Size ranking 85
Brightest stars Alpha (α) 3.2, Beta (β) 4.1
Genitive Circini
Abbreviation Cir
Highest in sky at 10pm May–June
Fully visible 19°N–90°S



CHART 2



Alpha (α) Circinus
 A white main-sequence star, 54 light-years away. Its orange dwarf companion of magnitude 8.6 is seen through a small telescope.

Circinus Galaxy
 A small spiral galaxy, 13 million light-years away, with an active supermassive black hole in its centre.